reluctant to put pen to paper, he was voluble in conversation, and loved to tell stories about his ideas and escapades. These anecdotes, accumulated over the years, helped add to his mystique and made him a proverbial legend in his own lifetime. His engaging manner endeared him greatly to students, especially the younger ones, many of whom idolized him. When Feynman died of cancer in 1988 the students at Caltech, where he had worked for most of his career, unfurled a banner with the simple message: “We love you Dick.”

It was Feynman’s happy-go-lucky approach to life in general and physics in particular that made him such a superb communicator. He had little time for formal lecturing or even for supervising Ph.D. students. Nevertheless he could give brilliant lectures when it suited him, deploying all the sparkling wit, penetrating insight, and irreverence that he brought to bear on his research work.

In the early 1960s Feynman was persuaded to teach an introductory physics course to Caltech freshmen and sophomores. He did so with characteristic panache and his inimitable blend of informality, zest, and offbeat humor. Fortunately, these priceless lectures were saved for posterity in book form. Though far removed in style and presentation from more conventional teaching texts, *The Feynman Lectures on Physics* were a huge success, and they excited and inspired a generation of students across the world. Three decades on, these volumes have lost nothing of their sparkle and lucidity. *Six Easy Pieces* is culled directly from *The Feynman Lectures on Physics.* It is intended to give general readers a substantive taste of Feynman the Educator by drawing on the early, nontechnical chapters from that landmark work. The result is a delightful volume—it serves both as a primer on physics for nonscientists and as a primer on Feynman himself.

What is most impressive about Feynman’s carefully crafted exposition is the way that he can develop far-reaching physical notions from the most slender investment in concepts, and a minimum in the way of mathematics and technical jargon. He has the knack of finding just the right analogy or everyday illustration to bring out the essence of a deep principle, without obscuring it in incidental or irrelevant details.

The selection of topics contained in this volume is not intended as a comprehensive survey of modern physics, but as a tantalizing taste of the Feynman approach. We soon discover how he can illuminate even mundane topics like force and motion with new insights. Key concepts are illustrated by examples drawn from daily life or antiquity. Physics is continually linked to other sciences while leaving the reader in no doubt about which is the fundamental discipline.